Scholarships

Discovery brief and questions for the in-person conversation

Built from the Scholarships Chair's written intake response of 27 September 2026, the compliance research behind it, and what the platform build has surfaced since. Everything attributed to her is from her own answers.

The legal material here is background research, not advice. Every item marked for counsel or a CPA needs professional sign-off before the organization acts on it.

The shape of the job

	Last cycle
Applications	150
Merit awards	119. Normally $500 to $2,500, occasionally $5,000
Wounded Patriot awards	64. A flat amount, **never told to us**
Total awards	183 across 150 applicants. Both, one, or neither
Her time, January to June	About 40 hours a month
Her time, the rest of the year	About 3 hours a month
Scorers	Four people besides her, with Submittable logins
Succession	A backup chair exists; they have swapped the role before

That is roughly 240 volunteer hours concentrated into six months. The two tasks she named as most draining are not the judgement calls: they are emailing each student their award amount, and mailing cheques to schools.

Tools and accounts she touches

Tool	What for	State
Submittable	The whole application cycle	About **$9,000 a year**. Org-owned, several admins including her
Wix	Scholarship info, twice a year	She has access but is not super user. **Owned by an individual no longer involved with the organization**
Google shared drive	Reception photos, the master list	Org-owned
Facebook	Scholarship updates and photos	Org account reached **through her personal login**
scholarships@thejsoa.org	Her mailbox	Checked directly, not forwarded

Membership spreadsheet	Eligibility check on every application	Opened by hand, every single time
A shared Excel file	Applicant personal data	Also on her **personal laptop**

What she said about security

Multi-factor authentication is **off**. Every account has exactly one person who can reach it. There is no formal offboarding process. Applicant data, including transcripts and disability documentation, sits in a shared spreadsheet and on a personal laptop. She does not know who holds super-admin on most things.

Her own self-assessment is the part worth reading back to the board. She agrees she could hand her role over cleanly, which makes her the exception. She disagrees that every account has MFA, that she would know who to call if an account were compromised, that member and donor data is only where it needs to be, and that the website and email could be recovered if the current owners vanished.

Pain points, in her words

“The website is a challenge as no one is in charge of it.”

- Submittable cannot email the applicant and their sponsor together. Students frequently do not read or answer, so she leaves the system entirely to reach the sponsoring member.
- Submittable has no field for the award amount, so she retypes 183 figures into emails by hand each cycle.
- Mailing cheques to schools is the other large time sink.
- Board members use personal email addresses, so she sends to every address she knows for a person.
- The Patriot Foundation split causes confusion. North Carolina residents at North Carolina schools now apply there directly, and she emails misrouted applicants afterwards to redirect them. In her words, “it is not ideal.”
- A newsletter has been raised before and stalled, because nobody offers and gathering the material is the work.

What she asked for, and agreed to

Her single biggest automation ask: **check the membership roster automatically when an application arrives.** Everything else was secondary.

On the board polls she said yes to publishing a sponsor ladder, routing corporate gifts to JSOF, a become-a-sponsor page, an annual impact report, recurring monthly giving, a members-only area, and rebuilding off Wix. She is comfortable with automation and AI assistance provided a person approves before anything goes out. She requires US hosting for scholarship applications specifically. She is open to replacing any tool that meets the need.

Her chosen measure of success: the scholarship cycle running end to end without email threads.

The legal ground, before you go in

Research, not advice. The first item should shape how the whole conversation is framed.

1. Eligibility is the big one, and it is not a technicality

Restricting awards to dependents of dues-paying members is the fact pattern the IRS uses to deny or revoke 501(c)(3) exemption: dues collected from members, scholarships paid to those members' children, is private benefit. Approved analogues define the class by **service connection and community** rather than by membership.

> Go in framing this as definitional rather than as a problem with her programme. The fix probably is definitional, and she did not write the rule.

2. Conflict of interest in selection

Board members are members, so their dependents are eligible, and a reviewer could face a colleague's child or their own. Expected: documented recusal, at least one committee member from outside the board, selection records retained five years, and no selector benefiting from a decision.

3. Minors

Under-13 data should not be collected at all. Under-18 applicants need affirmative guardian consent captured as a separate step with the guardian's own contact details, not a checkbox the student ticks. The eligibility dataset should be separated from the selection dataset, with an enforced retention period for unsuccessful applicants.

4. Never ingest a DD-214

Separation documents issued before roughly 2015 carry the member's full Social Security number. If the answer to “how do we verify service” ever becomes a document upload, the platform becomes a repository of SSNs belonging to special operations personnel.

5. She already does one thing exactly right

Scorers see the transcript and the application and never the disability evidence, which she verifies herself. She also named checking disability status as the one step that must never run without a person. Affirm both rather than proposing them.

6. FERPA sits with the schools, not with her

Cheques go to the institution, and the student's education records are the school's responsibility. Submittable advertises FERPA compliance, which signals a school-official posture rather than a transfer of duty to the Foundation.

7. The vendor chain is longer than the board knows

Submittable names sixteen subprocessors, two of them identity-verification and authentication services. Applicant data has been flowing further than anyone has disclosed, and whatever replaces it inherits the duty to describe that chain accurately.

8. North Carolina charitable solicitation

The exemption threshold is $50,000, not $25,000. There is **no** veterans' or fraternal exemption in the statute. The under-$50,000 route is not self-declaring and must be re-filed annually with supporting financials. Every contribution receipt must carry a specific disclosure in at least nine-point type, made conspicuous.

9. The reporting basis is unresolved

The cycle opens in December and awards land in spring, so it straddles calendar years, and the Foundation's fiscal year may differ from both. The 990 period is a third possibility. Nobody has told us which basis scholarships are reported on.

Questions for the in-person conversation

The survey got facts. These are the ones that need a conversation: judgement, context, and the things people do not write down. Each carries why it matters, so you can drop any that the discussion has already answered.

Unblocks the build. Ask these first.

1. What is the flat Wounded Patriot award amount?

Never supplied. It now propagates into the cumulative totals as well as the notifications, so it is holding up more than one screen.

2. Should a North Carolina resident at a North Carolina school applying for Merit only still be routed to the Patriot Foundation, or only Wounded Patriot applicants?

The routing rule is one line either way, and getting it wrong either strands an applicant or sends them somewhere that will turn them away.

3. Calendar year or fiscal year for reporting awards?

The cycle straddles both and the 990 is a third period. Everything cumulative is currently labelled per cycle because nobody has confirmed the basis.

4. How long should an unsuccessful applicant's data be kept?

We assumed one year with nothing to go on. The purge is written and tested; only the number is a guess.

5. Can we have the real school list before mid-December?

Twenty-four fictional schools are seeded. Cheques are payable to institutions, so this has to be real before the cycle opens.

The work itself. Where the edge cases live.

6. Walk me through the hardest award decision you made last cycle. What made it hard?

Edge cases are what break a workflow built from the happy path. The difficult one tells you more about the system you need than the other 149.

7. When a student does not respond, what do you actually do, and how many each cycle?

She leaves the system to chase the sponsor. Knowing the volume says whether copying the sponsor on every message solves it or only softens it.

8. Has an applicant or a parent ever challenged a decision? What happened?

Tells you what the record has to survive, and whether five-year retention of selection records is theoretical or has already been needed.

9. How do the four scorers actually coordinate? Do they discuss, or score in isolation?

Determines whether committee spread is a signal worth surfacing or just noise, and whether a shared view would help or bias them.

10. What happens today if two scorers disagree sharply on the same application?

There is no documented tie-break. If one exists in practice it should be written down; if it does not, that is a decision for the board.

11. How do you verify a Wounded Patriot claim? Walk me through one call.

78 verifications last cycle. The platform records the method and the note, but the actual practice should shape what those fields ask for.

Eligibility. Handle carefully.

She did not write this rule and should not be made to feel responsible for it. These are framed to establish provenance and consequences, not fault.

12. Do you know who set the “dependent child of a current JSOA member” rule, and when?

Establishes provenance. If it came from the bylaws or a founding document, changing it is a different conversation from changing a practice.

13. Have you ever had an applicant who clearly deserved it but did not meet that rule?

Makes the abstract legal risk concrete, and usually surfaces the real intent behind the rule.

14. If eligibility changed to be about service connection rather than membership, who would become eligible who is not now? Who would lose it?

This is the question that turns a legal fix into something the board can actually evaluate. It also tells you whether the change is small or seismic.

15. Does membership ever get taken out purely so a dependent can apply?

If dues are functioning as a price of admission to the scholarship, that is the private benefit problem in its plainest form, and she will know.

Continuity and risk. What only she knows.

16. If you had to hand this over in two weeks, what would you be most worried the next person gets wrong?

Better than asking what the process is. It surfaces the undocumented judgement that makes the role work.

17. Who else can get into Submittable today, and what happens to the historical submissions when it is switched off?

About $9,000 a year, and it holds the only record of who applied and who was awarded. Nobody has confirmed an export has ever been taken.

18. Where does the scholarship master list actually live, and who else can open it?

It is a shared spreadsheet that is also on a personal laptop. Knowing who has it is the first step to it not being there.

19. Should the backup chair have standing access, or access on handover?

A real succession answer either way, and it is the only role on the board that has one.

20. What do you wish the board understood about this role?

Ask it last. It is usually where the most useful thing in the conversation comes from.

Worth raising if there is time

21. Is the “over $2.5 million awarded to date” figure on the public site substantiated anywhere?

The public pages deliberately omit it because it could not be verified. If real, it is the strongest thing the organization can say; if not, it should come down.

22. Would knowing how many dependents graduate next year change how the fund is sized?

Nobody holds dependent data today. If the answer is yes, that is a membership-roster change with a clear payoff, and the Treasurer would benefit more than you would.

The one date that matters

The next cycle opens **mid-December**. The eligibility rule, the Wounded Patriot amount and the real school list are all on the critical path for it, and the first two need somebody other than her to decide.